

installed. In addition, you must have the Remote Desktop Connection software installed on the client PC.

Rock steady

This is the first time in Windows history that the rock-solid NT core has been included in a consumer-level OS. This itself is a major differentiator and explains why the XP stability is so hyped.

Microsoft, with each OS revision, goes further in integrating applications, whether it's a browser or a media player. XP sports applications that highlight the current market trends, for example, the addition of CD-writing, movie making, and so on.

An integrated CD-writer allows a user to burn CDs without third-party software, while a personal firewall provides protection against Internet threats. Other bundled perks include Windows Messenger and Windows Media Player, both of which have incorporated more features and functionality. In Messenger, there are significant improvements in audio fidelity which changes on-the-fly and thus adapts better to changing bandwidth conditions. In appearance, Messenger seems to have shed its older threads for the new XP attire. Windows Media Player innovates in its ability to playback DVDs and write audio CDs.

Compatibility

Even with its new enhancements, XP tries to provide compatibility with the previous versions. Older applications which were too closely designed around Windows 95 now have a chance at coming to life in XP. All one has to do is right-click on the application icon and select the Compatibility tab under Properties. Select the mode you want, click OK, and run the application.

We tested a few older applications to check XP's application supporting capability. There were programs such as Folder Guard and SigmaPlot 5 which were not executed even in the Windows 95 Compatibility Mode. However, older versions of applications such as Ahead Software's

Nero CD-Writing software operated just splendidly—no errors, no coasters.

XP also offers the multi-boot option in case you want your existing OS to remain.

No more plug-and-pray

Windows 95 had it, Windows NT didn't. Plug-and-play saw a true breakthrough in Windows 95; insert a video card or plug in a fancy mouse in the USB port and the operating system handles the rest. Plug-and-play takes care of touchy things like interrupts and IRQs. All you have to do is supply the correct drivers.

But the system wasn't perfected—since Windows 95 was so unstable, you had to plug in your devices and pray that the system wouldn't crash while detecting the device. With XP, you get the best of both worlds—hardware support from Windows 95 and stability from Windows NT.

Sharing, security, stability

XP is different, right from the moment you log in. It has revamped the login procedure and added a lot of flexibility when dealing with users. The login is friendly, and the interface friendlier. You can set a password for each individual user account or leave access open to anybody who wants to enter. Features normally present only in a network operating system such as the concept of administrator and different rights for different users find a place in XP. The administrator can also specify rights for programs.

Windows XP also bundles along an Internet Connection Firewall and an application-level firewall (this allows you to filter applications that can use the Internet) for protection from worms and malicious code.

Multi-level sharing and security features have always been a part of Windows since NT—the reason why NT/2000 has been a stable OS. The same stability is brought to XP based upon the core. All versions were prone to crashes in some way or the other after Windows 95.

After torture testing the XP, we noticed that during this time, we were

10 Explosive New Features

- 1** **A pretty picture**
Visually, no other Windows version could be as appealing as this. It's easier to use and is sleeker and more colourful than the predecessors.
- 2** **Easy does it**
User friendliness is accented in the Start menu that gives you quick access to recently run applications and the better organised taskbar. Icons give the user a clearer understanding of how to configure his or her PC.
- 3** **Stability**
For those tired of the Blue Screens and Illegal Operations, Windows XP Home edition leverages the stability of Windows 2000 using the NT core, to deliver a much more reliable computing experience.
- 4** **Quick starts**
Considerably faster boot-up than either Windows 2000 or Windows 98.
- 5** **Media savvy**
With Media Player 8, the Movie Maker video editing software, enhanced support for digital cameras and FireWire support you have the most multimedia friendly OS around.
- 6** **Going backwards**
Windows XP supports Compatibility Modes which allow the user to choose from Windows 95/98/NT/2000 emulation which lets even older programs run with ease.
- 7** **Network ready**
A plethora of friendly setup wizards assist you with basic steps such as setting up a network and network cabling. The Internet Connection Firewall protects you from hackers on the prowl.
- 8** **A real family PC**
XP's user friendliness is given a boost with support for multiple logins. Create a separate profile for your kid sister so she can play around without messing up your settings.
- 9** **Getting a helping hand**
Remote Assistance lets a friend help you when you are facing problems on your PC.
- 10** **Safety net**
A built-in rollback feature called System Restore allows you to go back to an older system configuration in case of a major problem.